Congress its largest basket of seats in a state in the 2009 general elections, Reddy had become a symbol of the Congress's electoral success. His death created a vacuum. His son Jaganmohan was keen to fill it and take over.

I had met Jagan just a few days before his father's tragic accident. Short but well built, he had the swagger of a mini Tollywood star. He wanted to make his Sakshi Television, he said, the largest regional television network in the country. 'It would be great if your channel can help me in this—we need your support,' he told me. I had heard about Jagan having become an extra-constitutional authority in Andhra—stories of alleged arm-twisting, vast riches and corruption were filtering through. I was keen to stay as far away as possible.

The accident changed all of Jagan's business plans. Now, he wanted to be chief minister. Only Sonia would not agree. At best, the party was ready to make him a minister of state at the Centre. A defiant Jagan decided to raise the stakes—he set off on an Odarpu (consolation) Yatra to grieve with the families of those who had self-immolated after his father's death. The yatra was his muscle-flexing moment, designed to convince the party high command that he was now Andhra's most popular leader.

Sonia, by all accounts, doesn't like being bullied. Jagan, she felt, was doing precisely that. At a meeting at 10, Janpath, with Jagan and his mother, Sonia drew a line—the Odarpu Yatra must be called off and no attempt must be made to destabilize the new chief minister of the state, the ageing K. Rosaiah.

The meeting went far worse than expected. When Sonia refused to meet Jagan's demands, his mother is reported to have hit back with, 'Would you have said the same thing if it was your son Rahul in Jagan's place? Why is my son being treated differently?' The duo were asked to leave at once. 'My mother and I were left feeling humiliated after all my father had done for the party,' Jagan later told me. Jagan decided there and then that he would form his own party, YSR Congress, taking with him a large chunk of Congress MLAs.

That wasn't the only Andhra blunder. More bizarrely, home minister Chidambaram made a sudden midnight announcement on a freezing winter